Sales Training Debrief — Session 26

Close the Gap with Referrals. The Asymmetric Bet.

Sales training led by Corie Dawson, Director · Friday 5 June 2026 · Marketing Sweet

1. Know what you want — or you won't get there

The session opened with a parallel that ran through everything afterwards: the way you treat your own goals is the way you treat your deals. Reps who don't know exactly what they want in their own life struggle to know exactly what they want from a deal — and that fuzziness shows up in the conversation. The vision board exercise (one short-term goal, one long-term goal, on the wall where the director can see it) isn't decorative. It's the same six-field discipline applied to the rep's life: when do you want it by, what is it, where do you need to be, what's the gap, what's holding you back, what are the conditions to make it happen.

> *"If you don't know what you want in life, you're not going to get it. That's why the vision board is so important. It's the same six fields. The way you treat your own goals is the way you treat your deals."*

The two parallel structures:

- Your goal: "In 12 months, I want a deposit on a house. Currently $30k saved, need $80k. Gap: $50k. What's holding me back: I'm not tracking weekly savings."
- Your deal: "Closing today. Pitched SEO Support + Page Building at $625/month. Client needs $500/month. Adjusted to SEO Support alone. Holding her back: $250 setup fee."
- Same shape. Same discipline. If you can do one, you can do the other.

2. The 6-field deal breakdown — applied in real time

Session 25 introduced the How to Close form. Session 26 walked it through with a live deal — Phil's SEO pitch from earlier in the week. The exercise revealed something important: most reps know what they're trying to say but can't say it in sequence, and the customer hears the gibberish before they hear the deal. Slow down. Write it in order. Then say it in order.

The six fields in the order they get filled and the order they get said:

1. When do I want the deal closed by? — "Today, by 3pm." Sets the urgency frame for everything else.
2. What did I pitch? — "SEO Support + 1× Page Building, which is $625/month + $250 setup fee." Product name first. Price second. Setup fee third. Same order, every time.
3. Where does the client need to be to close? — "She needs to be at $500/month." Her words, not your guess.
4. What did I end up offering? — "SEO Support on its own, $500/month + $250 setup fee." The next package down — not a discount, a different product.
5. What was the customer's reaction? What's holding them back? — "Much more relief on the price. Setup fee is the last blocker."
6. Closing conditions — "Setup fee waived. One blog article at no cost. Conditional on commit by Monday."

> *"We don't sell '$500.' We sell 'SEO Support, which is $500.' Product first. Price second. Setup fee third. Same English. Same sequence. Every time."*

3. Where the gap actually lives

The most important field on the form is field six — the closing conditions. The previous five fields are diagnostic. They tell the rep where they started, where the client is, and what the gap looks like. Field six is the creative work — the move that closes the gap. Most reps walk away from a deal at field five because they don't know how to do field six. That's the real skill being trained.

WALK AWAY (FAIL)	CLOSE THE GAP (WIN)
"I'll think about it" gets accepted at face value.	"I'll think about it" gets treated as a gap to close.
Rep drops the price unilaterally to close.	Rep finds a counterweight to offer instead of a pure drop.
The deal walks. Pipeline thins.	The deal closes — with something extra in it for both sides.
The next deal hits the same wall.	The technique compounds. Each close teaches the next one.

4. "I need to think about it" — what it actually means

The session was direct: when a buyer says they need to think about it, they don't. They've already decided. What "think about it" means is the rep has missed the mark — they haven't hit the price the buyer can say yes to, or they haven't built the value high enough to make the price feel right. The rep's job at that moment isn't to wait — it's to diagnose which one it is and act on it.

> *"Nine times out of ten, they don't need to think. You've missed the mark. The gap is either price or value. Find out which one, and close it."*

How to diagnose:

- If the buyer's body language drops at the price reveal — gap is price.
- If the buyer asks more questions about the work — gap is value (they want to be convinced).
- If the buyer gives a specific objection ("the setup fee") — gap is named, easier to close.
- If the buyer is vague ("just need to think") — push gently for the specific.

5. The cooler question

A specific technique introduced in this session. When the rep is about to make a big ask — a price drop request, a referral ask, a commitment request — they layer a second, gentler question on top. The second question "cools" the energy of the first, giving the buyer space to respond without feeling pressured. The two questions together produce far more agreement than either one alone.

> *"You've asked them for something — you actually put another question over the top of it to cool them down a bit. The second question covers the ask, and the buyer responds to both."*

Anatomy of the cooler:

7. First — make the real ask. "Can I ask you a quick question — can I have your business?"
8. Then — layer the cooler on top. "By the way — you've been in business 22 years. You must know a lot of people."
9. The buyer responds to the cooler first — "Yeah, I do know a lot of people" — which warms them up.
10. The real ask then gets the relaxed answer that follows the warm one.

Where to use it:

- Before a referral request.
- Before a price commitment ask.
- Before a calendar-lock request (when do you want me to call you back).
- Before any ask that the buyer's reflex would be to say no to.

6. Referrals as the asymmetric counterweight

The most powerful move in the session. When the buyer's gap is price — and the rep would otherwise drop the price unilaterally — the rep instead asks for referrals in exchange. The buyer gets the price they wanted. The rep gets a network of warm leads. The director gets a deal closed with something concrete to show for it. Three winners. The asymmetric bet.

> *"Just give me a list. Doesn't have to be the business names. Three to seven names of people you know in business. I'll go back to the director with that and the price you wanted. Done."*

The structure of the move:

11. Identify the gap. "Sounds like the price is the last blocker."
12. Layer the cooler. "By the way — you must know a lot of people in business after 22 years."
13. Make the ask. "Just give me three or four names — don't need business details, just names of people I could potentially talk to in four months if we do good work for you."
14. Pause. Take a few. Then ask for more. "Got any more? More is better."
15. Take the list to the director. "Here's the price. Here's the referrals. Deal done."
16. Come back to the buyer. "Director approved. We're on. Going to follow up monthly to make sure you get results — so I can call those referrals."

THE MATHS Seven referrals = approximately seventy cold calls saved (rough conversion). One asymmetric bet replaces a day's cold-calling work. Even five referrals is fifty calls. The trade is wildly in the rep's favour — and the buyer doesn't know that, because they got what they wanted.

7. Why this beats dropping the price alone

Dropping the price unilaterally signals two things — neither of them good. One, the original price was inflated (the buyer suspects everything else you said was too). Two, the rep will roll over under pressure (the buyer learns to push harder next time). Adding a counterweight — anything the buyer gives in exchange — reframes the transaction from a concession into a trade. Trades preserve value. Concessions destroy it.

> *"If you drop the price, you've literally undone every part of the value proposition you spent the whole pitch building. The integrity goes. You become the salesperson who folds. Add a counterweight, and the value stays."*

Counterweights that work:

- Referrals — strongest. Multiple warm leads in exchange for the price drop.
- Commitment to a longer term — six months instead of three.
- Permission for the rep to follow up monthly — turns the deal into a check-in cycle.
- A faster decision — "I can do that price if we commit today."

8. The director sell — the contingency framing

When the rep takes the deal back to the director, the language matters. The word the session insisted on was contingency. Not "discount" — discount is a giveaway. Contingency frames it as a conditional approval: we'll grant the price the buyer wants, contingent on the referrals being real, contingent on the deal closing today, contingent on the buyer's commitment to a follow-up cadence.

> *"Use the word contingency. Not discount. Contingency. The director approved the price, contingent on the referrals. The buyer hears that they earned the deal — and the value stays intact."*

The script when calling the buyer back:

- "Look — I've got fantastic news. The director approved the price you wanted."
- "It came with one contingency — that you're happy to pass on a few referrals if we deliver good work over the next few months."
- "I'm going to personally check in with you in month one, month two, month three to make sure the team's delivering. If we do, you make the introductions. Sound fair?"

9. The handover close — momentum through the transition

Once the deal is done, the rep doesn't walk away. They explicitly set up the handover with momentum — naming the account manager, scheduling check-ins, attaching themselves to the buyer's success. This does three things at once: it reassures the buyer (they were worried about post-sale drop-off), it secures the referral pipeline (the rep needs to be in contact to collect), and it makes the next deal easier (because the buyer now sees the agency as a partner, not a vendor).

The handover script:

17. "Welcome aboard. I'm going to personally hand you over to Taylor — she'll be your account manager."
18. "I'll check in with you at month one. Just to see how the campaign's running."
19. "Same again at month two. By month three we should be seeing the first real movement."
20. "If we're delivering what you wanted, I'll come back to you about those referrals. Sound fair?"

10. Selling as a craft — not a transaction

The session closed on a reframe. New reps treat selling as a transaction — pitch, price, close, done. Experienced reps treat selling as a craft — a structured sequence of moves that produce predictable outcomes when run well. The six-field form, the cooler question, the referral counterweight, the contingency framing, the handover close — none of these are tactics. They're the craft. Reps who learn the craft compound. Reps who run tactics plateau.

> *"You don't realise how skilful selling actually is. It's a craft. Follow the sequence verbatim, and the results come. Improvise it, and you'll struggle for years."*

11. Action items this week

21. Fill in the How to Close form (Session 25) on every live deal this week — before you come to the director.
22. Practise the cooler question. Layer one onto every ask that matters.
23. Try the referral counterweight on at least one stalled deal. Ask for 3–7 names in exchange for a price contingency.
24. Use the word "contingency" — never "discount" — when explaining the deal back to the buyer.
25. Set up the handover close on every closed deal — month 1, month 2, month 3 check-ins by name.
26. Put your own goals on the wall. One short-term, one long-term. Where the director can see them.

THE ONE-LINER Know what you want. Run the six fields. Cool the ask. Take referrals as the counterweight. Call it a contingency. Hand over with momentum.